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Add Services

Summary

A service in clan is a self-contained, reusable unit of system configuration that provides a specific piece of functionality across one or more machines.

Think of it as a recipe for running a tool – like automatic backups, VPN networking, monitoring, etc.

In Clan, services are multi-host and role-based:

- Roles map machines to logical service responsibilities, enabling structured and clean deployments.
- You can use tags instead of explicit machine names.

In this step of the guide, we will add two of the most frequently used services to your new setup: Networking and ssh.

To learn more about services in general, visit [Clan Services](#)

Important

It is recommended to always add at least one networking service such as `zerotier` that can reach all your clan machines from your setup computer. We will do so in the following steps.

Requirements

- Estimated time: 15 minutes

- A Clan with at least one machine and at least one user prepared as described in the previous steps

Configure a ZeroTier Network

Add the configuration for a ZeroTier Network to your `clan.nix` file as follows:

`clan.nix`



```
1 {
2     inventory.machines = {
3         jon-machine = { };
4         sara-machine = { };
5     };
6
7     inventory.instances = {
8         zerotier = {
9             # Replace with the name (string) of your machine that you will use
10            # See: https://docs.zerotier.com/controller/
11            # Deploy this machine first to create the network secrets
12            roles.controller.machines."jon-machine" = { }; #edit your machine name
13            # Peers of the network
14            # this line means 'all' clan machines will be 'peers'
15            roles.peer.tags.all = { };
16        };
17    };
18 }
```

See [services/official](#) for all available services and how to configure them.

Or read [guides/services](#) if you want to bring your own!

Adding more recommended defaults: SSH Access

Adding ssh keys is one of the most recommended services:

`clan.nix`

```
1 {
2     inventory.machines = {
3         jon-machine = { };
4         sara-machine = { };
5     };
6     inventory.instances = {
7         admin = {
8             roles.default.tags.all = { };
9             roles.default.settings = {
10                 allowedKeys = {
11                     "root" = "ssh-ed25519 AAAAC3N...";
12                 };
13             };
14         };
15     };
16 }
```

The `admin` service will generate a **root-password** and **add your ssh-key** that allows for convenient administration to all machines.

This method is equivalent to directly setting `authorizedKeys` like in [configuring a machine](#)

Checkpoint

❖ Under Construction

We are working on a feasible solution to test your progress up to this point. Unfortunately, there are currently no checkpoints available.

Up Next

We will deploy your configuration to either a bare metal physical machine or a virtual machine.

Please select your path accordingly:

[Next Step: Prepare Physical Machines](#)

[Next Step: Prepare Virtual Machines](#)

You can have a mix of both if you like. In that case, simply follow the respective guide per machine type.

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Prepare Physical Machines

Need help? Reach out to [our community](#).